Perfect Moments

By Brian Finkelstein

BRIAN: **(Pg 373-384)** So the standard commitment to work at the Humanitarian Suicide Hotline is six months. Most people work six months, and then leave, quickly. A few make it a year. I was a volunteer there for four years. It started when I was twenty-two years old, and I believed in things. I thought I could help the world.

INTRODUCTION

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BRIAN: So one Saturday morning, I walk into this church, and there's a bunch of people milling about, but I see this guy that's clearly in charge. He tells us his name is Glen. And he's got a little bit of a Louis Gossett, Jr., drill sergeant thing going on, because as soon as he starts the training class, he's starting to weed people out.

One of the most important things Glen weeded out was people who were either suicide survivors, meaning they'd lost somebody because of suicide, or because they themselves, had contemplated suicide.

At the end of two weeks of training, out of fifty-eight people who came to volunteer, there were only four of us left, because Glen was really good . . . But I was better. Because what Glen didn't know about me was that about four years before this, I was dating this girl Tracy. Tracy slept with my best friend. And Glen didn't know that my father's a retired cop. I took his .38 and I drove to Torrey Pines Beach. Glen has no idea how good it feels to stick a loaded gun in your mouth . . to have control.

And I sat there, trying to contemplate doing it, and then . . . I threw up all over the gun. There's nothing snaps you out of a suicide impulse more than throwing up on a gun. And I thought to myself, *Well, at least I know I'm not the type of person that's gonna pull the trigger.* And I felt this moment of clarity. It was late at night. Beautiful full moon. I sat there and I realized that's what life is. There are these moments of beauty, like moons and oceans,

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and then there are moments of horror. And then it's good again. And for me that was enough. But Glen didn't know any of that because I never told him.

So, at the end of two weeks of training class we [are ready for] the hotline room. There's a sign that hangs on the wall that says the motto of the hotline, which is SHUT UP AND LISTEN. It's how you prevent suicides . . . by listening to people.

A lot of people think about suicide, but most people don't really go the next step. The closest thing to a warning sign for suicide is if somebody says something like "I don't want to die. I just want the pain to stop." And if you hear somebody say that -- that they want the pain to stop -- a bell should go off. That's a person who's on the edge. [I'll never forget my last night at the hotline] . . .

BRIAN: Hello, Humanitarians, can I help you?

AMY: *(scared)* Hi. My name is Amy. I'd like to talk.

BRIAN: What's up, Amy? What's going on?

AMY: I was just calling because I was feeling a little sad.

BRIAN: Oh, what are you sad about?

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AMY: Ah, I don't know, things are pretty good. I have good grades at school, and my parents don't get it, but they love me.

BRIAN: Well, that sounds good. But you said you were sad. What do you think about when that happens?

AMY: I don't know. I can't control it. Sometimes when I have a great day, I try to duplicate it. I wake up at the same time, I eat the same food, try to have the same pattern, so that I don't feel bad.

BRIAN: *(to audience)* But then, out of nowhere, she said, she felt a hand coming from behind her and pushing her down. *(to Amy)* Okay, what's going on when that happens? What are you thinking about?

AMY: Everything, nothing . . . I just feel so stupid.

BRIAN: *(to audience)* So we were [just] talking like that. And I noticed that it was about time to wrap it up, but Amy started telling me this story about going to some place with her family one day, and their father bought ice cream, and it was a great day. But then [she] started to slur her speech a little bit.

BRIAN: Amy, what's going on? Are you okay?

AMY: *(slurred speech)* Yeah. Look, I know it's selfish, but I

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can't do it anymore. I just want it to stop.

BRIAN: What do you mean? What do you mean by 'it'?

AMY: Look, I don't want to die. I just want the pain to stop.

BRIAN: *(to audience)* ***And I woke up.*** Amy, do you feel so bad that you think about suicide?

AMY: Yes.

BRIAN: Do you have a plan for how you would do it?

AMY: Yes.

BRIAN: Have you set a time for when you're gonna do it?

AMY: Uh-huh.

BRIAN: Amy, have you taken any steps today to kill yourself?

AMY: Yes.

BRIAN: Amy, what have you done? *(to audience)* And she told me she took twenty painkillers. And she started to cry. *(to Amy)* Amy, do you want help? Do you want me to do something? I can do something, but I can only help you if you ask. *(to audience)* Our policy was not to intervene unless people asked us to.

AMY: I do. I don't want to do this.

BRIAN: Great, what's your address? *(to audience)* She gave me her address and [as I alerted 911] I kept Amy

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talking. *(to Amy)* Uh, Amy, what kind of ice cream was it that your father bought you? You mentioned that your father bought you ice cream. What *kind* of ice cream was it? *(to audience)* But it was silent. And it was silent for two minutes. And it was silent for five minutes. And I'm supposed to hang up the phone, but who the hell could hang up the phone? So I didn't. And then around thirteen, fourteen minutes, I heard noises, people knocking, and then I heard the door crash open. And then I heard the phone being picked up, and a voice said, "It's okay. We've got her." ***Click.***

I went home. I was supposed to go to class that day at Queens College. But I never went back. I never graduated. I was supposed to go back to the hotline for a debriefing based on that phone call. But I called Glen and told him I quit, that I wasn't coming back. And then I did all the things you're not supposed to do. I looked through the papers and listened to the radio, and finally, after three days, I found it. In the ***Daily News,*** page 23, a small paragraph that said they had found the body of a nineteen-year-old NYU student named Amy Walters who had died of an overdose.

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I didn't know until that moment that she was dead, and I was the last person to talk to her. Not her mom, or her best friend, or some boy at NYU that probably had a crush on her but never talked to her. . . Me.

I spoke to her for less than an hour *many* years ago. But I think about it every day . . . She's me, in that car. If I had pulled the trigger, that would be me. And she never got to find out what I got to find out, which is it's terrible sometimes . . . but there are these perfect life moments . . . And that's enough.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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